

## Safety and piety: On safety and religious pilgrimage sites

A sense of fairness must **drive** the **capping** of visitors to religious sites

Despite the hundreds of thousands who **throng** the Tirumala temple in Tirupati every year for the Vaikunta Ekadasi celebrations, **stampedes** at the world-renowned hill temple **have** been rare. However, the tragic incident on January 8, 2025 **underscores** the need to rethink crowd management strategies at religious pilgrimage sites. As an editorial in this daily on December 27, 2024, noted, India has the highest number of religious stampedes globally. According to National Crime Records Bureau data, between 1996 and 2022, over 3,000 lives were lost in stampedes at religious events **nationwide**. This statistic **starkly highlights** the need for **systemic** changes in the way **large-scale** gatherings are organised and managed. The Tirupati **stampede**, which **resulted in** six **devotees passing away** and injuries to over 40 others, **was** despite the **extensive** arrangements by the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD) and the Andhra Pradesh government. **Elaborate** crowd control **mechanisms**, such as a **well-dispersed** token distribution strategy and the **deployment** of over 3,000 police personnel and other staff and volunteers were **in place** for the 10-day Vaikunta Dwara Darshan. **Nonetheless**, what appears to be miscommunication at one of the centres in the city to handle a **surge** in devotees at a token distribution centre, seems to have **triggered chaos** and panic. The **probe** that Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu announced **would shed** more light on where the **lapse** occurred. The tragedy **unfolded** just weeks after another stampede-like situation in Hyderabad. While the TTD has been making **commendable** efforts over the years to **streamline** operations — online booking systems and additional security personnel during peak periods — the scale and the **spontaneity** of human behaviour at such events demand innovative solutions.

One such idea could involve prioritising **pilgrims** who have never visited Tirupati over repeat visitors, thereby ensuring a more **equitable** darshan. VIP darshans too need a rethink. A **robust** database and a **roster system** could help regulate devotee flow and ensure fairness. Additionally, there is a need to consider the **ecological** impact on the Tirumala Hills, which are a part of the Seshachalam Biosphere Reserve. Growing anthropogenic pressures **stemming from deforestation, urbanisation**, and massive **footfalls pose** a significant threat to its **biodiversity**. **Balancing** the human need to connect with the **divine** with the **imperative** to **preserve** nature **requires** innovative and **sustainable** approaches. These could include capping the number of pilgrims every day, promoting virtual darshan experiences, and enforcing stricter conservation policies. A collaborative **effort** between religious and government authorities, environmental experts, and the public **is** essential to create a framework that prioritises safety, **accessibility**, and ecological preservation.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

## Vocabulary

1. **Piety** (noun) – Devotion, reverence, sanctity, faithfulness, holiness भक्ति/धार्मिकता
2. **Pilgrimage** (noun) – Journey, expedition, voyage, spiritual travel, quest तीर्थयात्रा
3. **Drive** (verb) – Propel, motivate, push, compel, urge प्रेरित करना
4. **Capping** (noun) – Limitation, restriction, ceiling, upper limit, boundary सीमा निर्धारण
5. **Throng** (verb) – Crowd, swarm, gather, flock, pack भीड़ लगाना
6. **Stampede** (noun) – Rush, surge, dash, panic, tumult भगदड़
7. **Underscore** (verb) – Emphasize, highlight, stress, underline, accentuate बल देना
8. **Nationwide** (adjective) – Across the country, countrywide, pan-national, national, all over the nation राष्ट्रव्यापी
9. **Starkly** (adverb) – Harshly, clearly, bluntly, severely, vividly स्पष्ट रूप से
10. **Highlight** (verb) – Emphasize, underline, spotlight, accentuate, draw attention to जोर देना
11. **Systemic** (adjective) – Structural, organized, comprehensive, ingrained, institutional प्रणालीगत
12. **Large-scale** (adjective) – Extensive, massive, widespread, grand, broad बड़े पैमाने का
13. **Result in** (phrasal verb) – Lead to, cause, bring about, produce, end in परिणामस्वरूप होना
14. **Devotee** (noun) – Worshipper, follower, adherent, disciple, believer भक्त
15. **Pass away** (phrasal verb) – Die, expire, depart, deasease, succumb निधन होना
16. **Extensive** (adjective) – Comprehensive, widespread, vast, thorough, large व्यापक
17. **Elaborate** (adjective) – Detailed, intricate, thorough, complex, exhaustive विस्तृत
18. **Mechanism** (noun) – System, structure, process, apparatus, method प्रणाली/तंत्र
19. **Well-dispersed** (adjective) – Spread out, well-distributed, evenly scattered, allocated, spaced out अच्छी तरह बिखरा हुआ
20. **Deployment** (noun) – Utilization, arrangement, mobilization, positioning, assignment तैनाती
21. **In place** (phrase) – Established, implemented, ready, prepared, positioned लागू
22. **Nonetheless** (adverb) – However, still, yet, even so, nevertheless फिर भी
23. **Surge** (noun) – Increase, rise, wave, swell, upswing वृद्धि

24. **Trigger** (verb) – Initiate, cause, start, provoke, spark उत्प्रेरित करना
25. **Chaos** (noun) – Disorder, turmoil, confusion, mayhem, disarray अराजकता
26. **Probe** (noun) – Investigation, inquiry, examination, exploration, scrutiny जांच
27. **Shed** (verb) – Emit, release, discard, throw light on, remove छोड़ना/उजागर करना
28. **Lapse** (noun) – Failure, mistake, error, oversight, shortcoming चूक
29. **Unfold** (verb) – Reveal, develop, open up, happen, occur उजागर होना
30. **Commendable** (adjective) – Admirable, praiseworthy, laudable, noteworthy, exemplary प्रशंसनीय
31. **Streamline** (verb) – Simplify, organize, optimize, rationalize, modernize सुगम बनाना
32. **Spontaneity** (noun) – Impulsiveness, naturalness, unplanned action, freedom, instinctiveness स्वाभाविकता
33. **Pilgrim** (noun) – Worshipper, devotee, traveler, seeker, visitor तीर्थयात्री
34. **Equitable** (adjective) – Fair, just, impartial, unbiased, reasonable न्यायसंगत
35. **Robust** (adjective) – Strong, sturdy, reliable, durable, effective मजबूत
36. **Roster system** (noun) – Scheduling system, timetable, register, list, allocation system अनुसूची प्रणाली
37. **Ecological** (adjective) – Environmental, natural, green, sustainable, biological पर्यावरणीय
38. **Stem from** (phrasal verb) – Originate, arise, derive, come from, result from उत्पन्न होना
39. **Deforestation** (noun) – Clearing of forests, tree-cutting, logging, forest depletion, denuding वनों की कटाई
40. **Urbanisation** (noun) – Urban growth, city development, modernization, metropolitan expansion, urban sprawl शहरीकरण
41. **Footfall** (noun) – Number of visitors, attendance, turnout, traffic, flow आगंतुकों की संख्या
42. **Pose** (verb) – Present, create, raise, constitute, introduce उत्पन्न करना
43. **Biodiversity** (noun) – Variety of life, ecological diversity, biological variety, ecosystem variety, life forms जैव विविधता
44. **Divine** (adjective) – Sacred, holy, godly, spiritual, heavenly दिव्य/पवित्र
45. **Imperative** (noun) – Necessity, requirement, priority, obligation, essential आवश्यकता
46. **Preserve** (verb) – Protect, conserve, maintain, safeguard, uphold संरक्षित करना

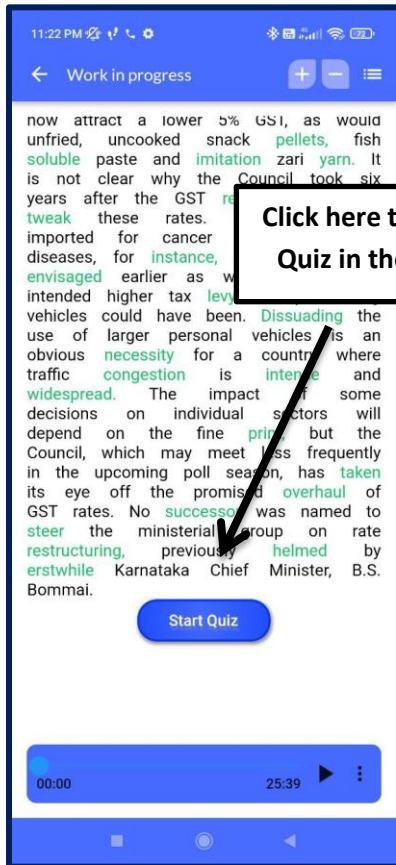
47. **Sustainable** (adjective) – Eco-friendly, viable, renewable, enduring, long-lasting टिकाऊ
48. **Accessibility** (noun) – Availability, approachability, reachability, ease of use, inclusiveness पहुंच/सुलभता

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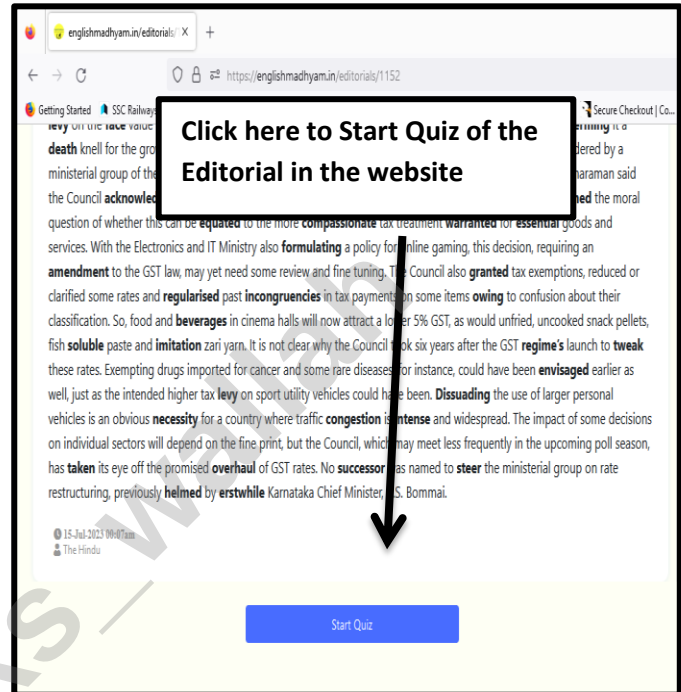
## Summary of the Editorial

1. **Stampede Tragedy at Tirupati:** The January 8, 2025, stampede at Tirupati temple highlights the need to improve crowd management strategies at religious pilgrimage sites.
2. **Global Religious Stampede Issue:** India leads globally in religious stampedes, with over 3,000 deaths recorded between 1996 and 2022, according to the National Crime Records Bureau.
3. **Existing Crowd Management Efforts:** The Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD) and Andhra Pradesh government deployed elaborate crowd control mechanisms, including token distribution and 3,000 personnel, during the 10-day Vaikunta Dwara Darshan.
4. **Trigger for Chaos:** Miscommunication at a token distribution centre likely triggered the stampede, underscoring the need for systemic improvements.
5. **Need for Investigation:** A probe announced by Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu aims to identify lapses in the crowd management process.
6. **Recurrent Challenges:** The tragedy follows another stampede-like incident in Hyderabad, indicating systemic vulnerabilities in managing large gatherings.
7. **Commendable Innovations:** Measures such as online booking systems and additional security during peak periods are positive steps but need further enhancement.
8. **Prioritizing First-Time Visitors:** Prioritizing first-time pilgrims over repeat visitors could ensure more equitable access to darshan.
9. **Rethinking VIP Darshans:** VIP darshans require a rethink to balance accessibility and fairness for all devotees.
10. **Technology for Regulation:** A robust database and roster system could help regulate the flow of devotees and improve crowd management.
11. **Ecological Concerns:** The Tirumala Hills, part of the Seshachalam Biosphere Reserve, face environmental challenges due to deforestation, urbanization, and heavy footfall.
12. **Balancing Nature and Faith:** Balancing human spiritual needs with ecological preservation requires sustainable and innovative approaches.
13. **Daily Visitor Caps:** Capping the number of daily pilgrims can mitigate overcrowding and ensure a safer environment.
14. **Virtual Darshan:** Promoting virtual darshan experiences can help reduce physical footfalls while preserving the sanctity of the pilgrimage.
15. **Collaborative Framework Needed:** Collaboration between religious authorities, governments, environmental experts, and the public is essential to prioritize safety, accessibility, and conservation.

## Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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